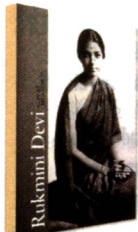


Dancing on the EDGE

Rich in historical details, this biography still misses the woman behind the legend

| By Ashish Mohan Khokar |



**RUKMINI DEVI:
A LIFE**

by LEELA SAMSON

Viking

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Making history is easier than writing history. This holds very true of an enigmatic figure like Rukmini Devi Arundale (1904-1986). She was an iconic name in the world of Indian dance, vegetarianism and animal rights. A nominated Member of Parliament for two terms, she was also a preferred candidate for the President of India by fellow leap-year born Morarji Desai. Typical of the woman, she refused the post, saying, "If there is a division of opinion, the post is not worth it." Imagine, refusing such a post just because of lack of unity amongst parties or parliamentarians? Her story or history, as undertaken by her inspired student Leela Samson, a dancer of repute and now the director of Kalakshetra, the institution Rukmini Devi created, is replete with facets hitherto not much known in mainstream historiography.

Samson is an intelligent story-teller for she has not avoided any of the key controversies that surrounded Rukmini Devi's life: be it her entry

into the dance world, being positioned as a brahminical foil to the dance of the Devadasis, or her marriage to a foreigner, older than her by 26 years. The first 60 pages or so hardly mention Rukmini Devi, as Samson masterfully lays the topography of the land, its immediate socio-political scapes and contexts and concerns that dominated pre-Independence India. Annie Besant and other luminaries associated with the Theosophical Movement is what forms the bedrock of this narrative. For it is in this setting that Rukmini Devi flowers and arrives centre-stage. Samson is balanced in her reporting of Rukmini's debut performance, stand-offs with the brahminical fraternity opposed to her dancing and the pitting of Rukmini against Balasaraswati. She meticulously reconstructs the travails of setting up of Kalakshetra, after its delinking from its parent body, the Theosophical Society. Many of the key players who created mischief to keep this mistress of art out fighting court battles instead of creating art are profiled without judgment or rancour.

Somewhere, Samson's guarded and correct approach reflects a student writing about her teacher. There is lot of awe but no attempt at an assessment or putting in context the process of institution-building against all odds. The pain of creating Kalakshetra is there; the progress (and realisation) of the dream is left to the reader to surmise. The persona of Rukmini Devi—her real self, the emotional, human side—does not come through enough, or effectively. Facts, historical data and events show up more. Her life looks historical; the person behind the history, the real Rukmini Devi, is somewhat missing.

Historically rich, this book is almost the history of all movements prevalent in pre-Independence India: the Theosophist, the occultist, the nationalist and even the communist, though in passing. Samson lays no claim to being a biographer, less still a historian, but she succeeds as both and that, coming from a nationally reputed dancer and thinker, is commendable. Samson writes in fine prose, often reflective, sometimes deep and she keeps her own part minimal. The book is a fine, excellent tribute to the great thinker-artist-seer and seeker that Rukmini Devi was. ■

RAGHU RAI



RUKMINI DEVI